Hitting the Right Notes

HERE'S MUSIC TO MANY EARS! India's oldest music label, Saregama, has found a new lease of life under Avarna Jain's stewardship. "Saregama was the market leader in the '80s but slowly lost its position. This was worrisome. We were sitting on this repository of Indian music that was gold, and weren't doing anything about it," says Avarna, vice-chairperson of Saregama India. Formerly known as The Gramophone Company of India Ltd, and more popularly as HMV (His Master's Voice), Saregama was established in 1901 as the first overseas Indian branch of Electric & Musical Industries Ltd, London. Today, the company—owned by Kolkata-headquartered RP-Sanjiv Goenka Group with a revenue of $4.3 billion (Rs 36,000 crore)—has the largest repertoire of music under its label in India, has entered into the OTT film, live concerts, and movie production segments as well. How did Avarna steer the company into the digital age? "By investing in the right team. We wanted people with dynamism and a different mindset, not weighed down with the baggage of the past," says the daughter of Sanjiv Goenka.

Avarna also heads the *Hello!* magazine. And in the pipeline is the well-known American men's magazine *Esquire*, set to hit the stands in India next year through a partnership with RPSG Lifestyle, led by Avarna.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
She has turned around Saregama, making it a billion-dollar company

One of her biggest professional achievements, however, remains the launch of Carvaan, a retro-style jukebox that comes pre-loaded with a vast collection of songs from various genres. "This was a huge turning point and resulted in Saregama becoming a billion-dollar company," says Avarna. Recently, Saregama acquired Pocket Aces, a digital entertainment company. "This step signifies the confluence of tradition and innovation and will help tap into the young digital audiences," says Avarna. Pocket Aces has an IP catalogue of over 3,000 pieces of content and a network of over 95 million followers. The company's talent management arm, Clout, manages over 100 digital influencers. Saregama is also planning more niche versions of Carvaan which already has some variants in the market.

Given all her work commitments, Avarna says finding a work-life balance is not always simple. "I sometimes feel there aren't enough hours in a day! On a serious note, I have an extremely supportive family, but it all comes down to planning and prioritising. If I don't calendar something, you can be sure I'm not doing it," she notes. ■

–Sonali Acharjee

YASIR IQBAL



Avarna Jain, *38*
Vice-chairperson, Saregama India

DITCH THE GUILT

"Never underestimate yourself, never let guilt get the better of you; that said, there's no shortcut to hard work and commitment"

RELAXATION MANTRA
Unwinding with her two adorable children. "If I get a moment from that, then read, and watch some shows on OTT"